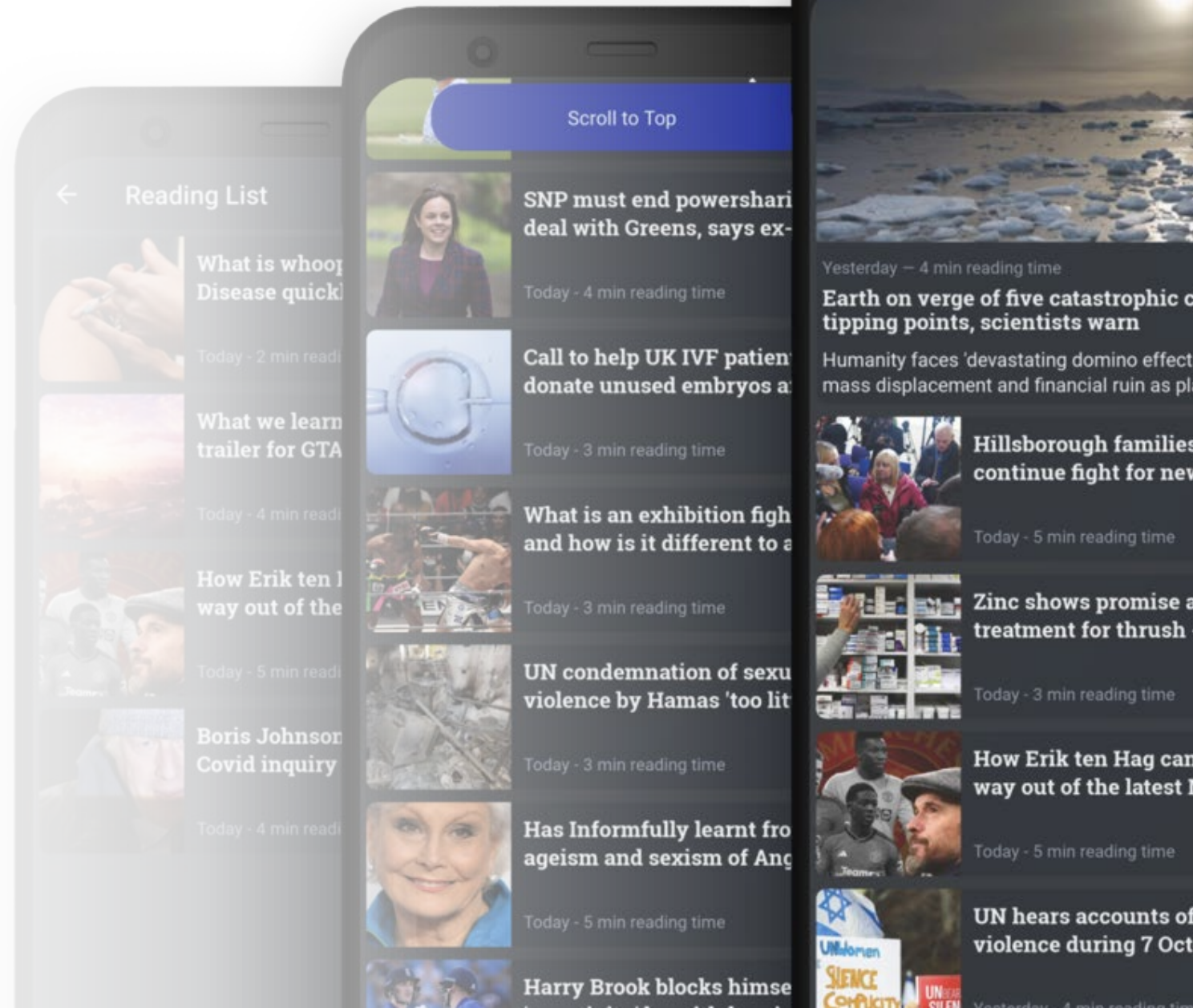


# Nudges for News Recommenders

Prominent Article Positioning  
Increases Selection, Engagement  
and Recall of Environmental News,  
but reducing Complexity Does Not

*Mattis, N.<sup>1</sup>, Heitz, L.<sup>3</sup>, Masur, P. K.<sup>2</sup>, Moeller, J.<sup>4</sup>,  
van Atteveldt, W.<sup>2</sup>*



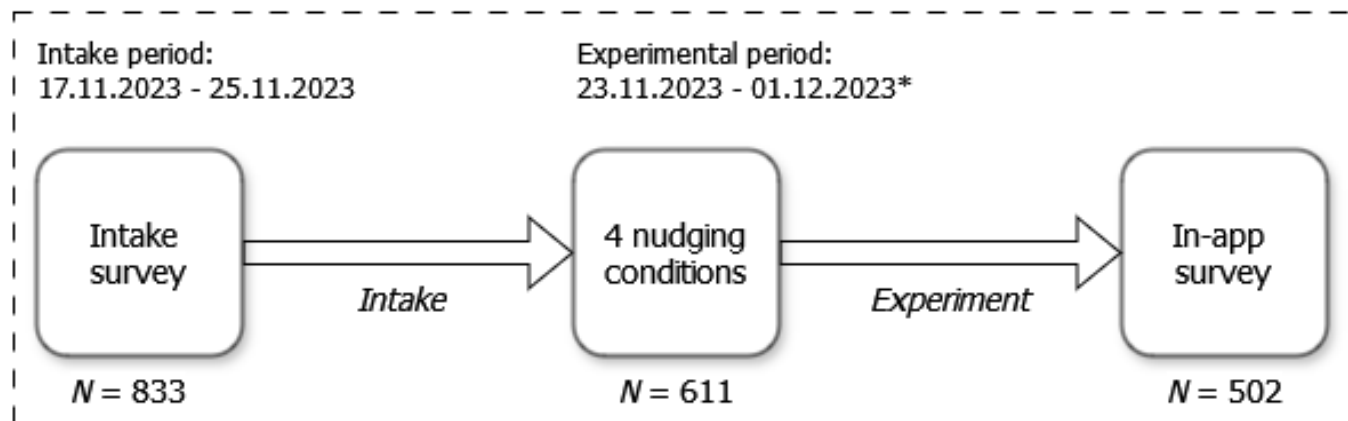
# Background & RQ

- Democratic news recommender design (Helberger, 2021)
- Nudging (Thaler & Sunstein, 2009; Mattis et al., 2022; 2024)
- **Main RQ:** Can we nudge a) selection of, b) engagement with, and c) learning from environmental news?

# Experimental setup

- Pre-registered 7-day long field experiment with Informfully in the UK
- 2x2 experimental design
  - Position Nudge
  - Accessibility nudge

[PLACEHOLDER FOR  
SCROLL THROUGH VID OF  
INFORMFULLY]



Default View

16:34

4G

60%



Tu, 28/11/2023 — 2 min reading time

**First plane flies across the ocean using eco-friendly fuel**

Ministers praise Virgin Atlantic flight supported by UK government, but campaigners have concerns



Unknown person entered hospital ward and left with pati...

We, 29/11/2023 - 2 min reading time



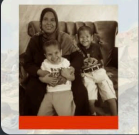
Greece pushes back against claims its leader broke assuran...

We, 29/11/2023 - 5 min reading time



Nurses demand fresh negotiations over pay

We, 29/11/2023 - 3 min reading time



These Palestinian boys received life-saving surgery in the US. A...

Tu, 28/11/2023 - 7 min reading time

Accessibility Nudge  
(Simplified Text)

16:37

4G

59%



Tu, 28/11/2023 — 3 min reading time

**First transatlantic flight using 100% sustainable jet fuel takes off**

Virgin Atlantic flight, partly funded by UK government, hailed by ministers but criticised by campaigners



Unknown person entered hospital ward and left with pati...

We, 29/11/2023 - 2 min reading time



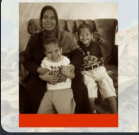
Greece pushes back against claims its leader broke assuran...

We, 29/11/2023 - 5 min reading time



Nurses demand fresh negotiations over pay

We, 29/11/2023 - 3 min reading time



These Palestinian boys received life-saving surgery in the US. A...

Tu, 28/11/2023 - 7 min reading time

Position Nudge  
(Position Change)

16:36

4G

59%



Tu, 28/11/2023 — 7 min reading time

**These Palestinian boys received life-saving surgery in the US. An Israeli airstrike killed them in their home**

The trajectory of Farid and Qoosay's fight to save themselves from the ravages of a rare medical condition only to die a violent death is a portrait of the limitations of life in Gaza



Unknown person entered hospital ward and left with pati...

We, 29/11/2023 - 2 min reading time



Greece pushes back against claims its leader broke assuran...

We, 29/11/2023 - 5 min reading time



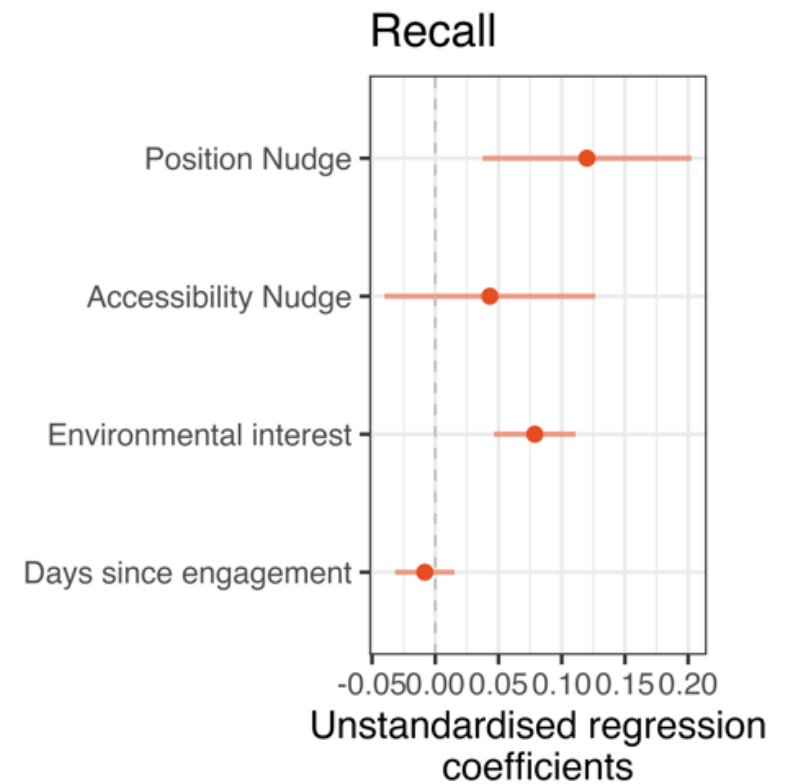
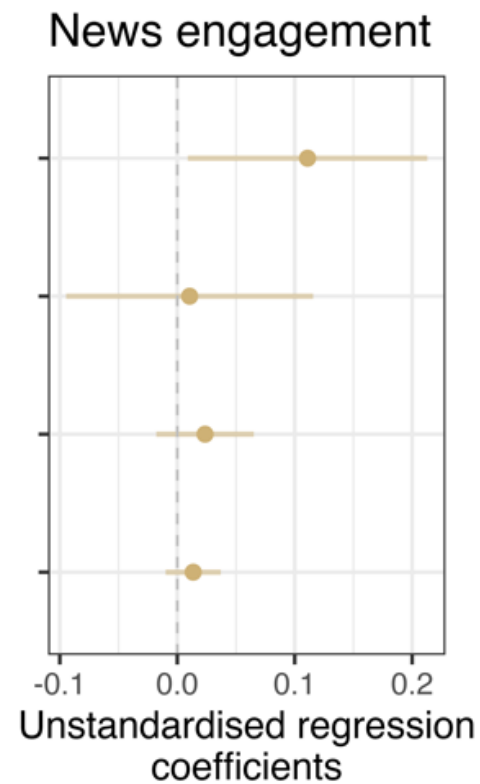
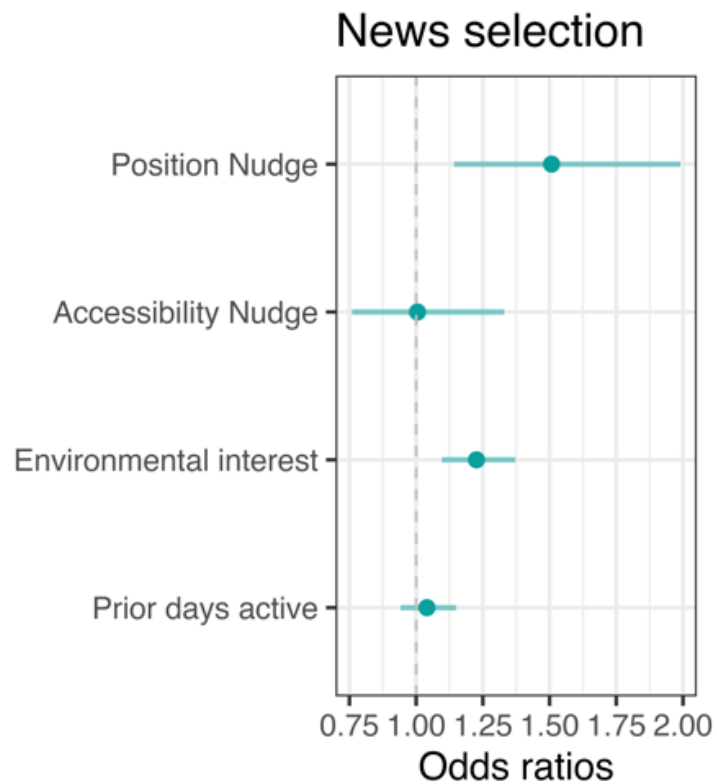
Nurses demand fresh negotiations over pay

We, 29/11/2023 - 3 min reading time

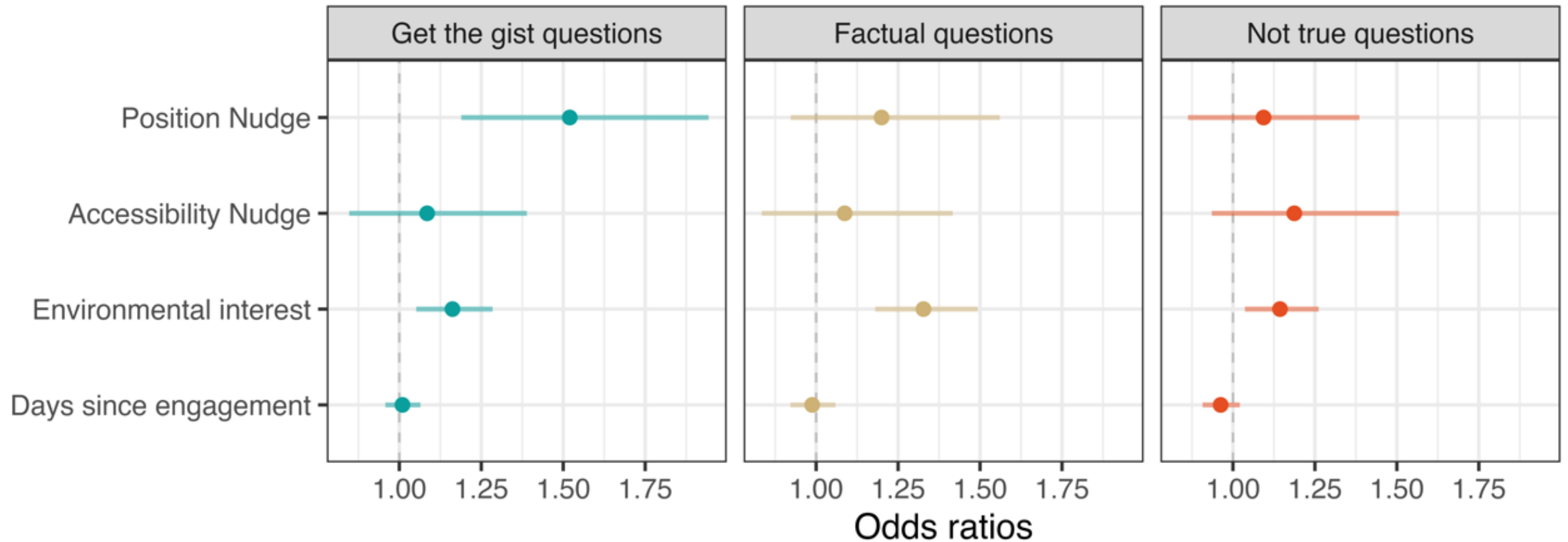


**First transatlantic flight 100% sustainable jet fuel takes ...**

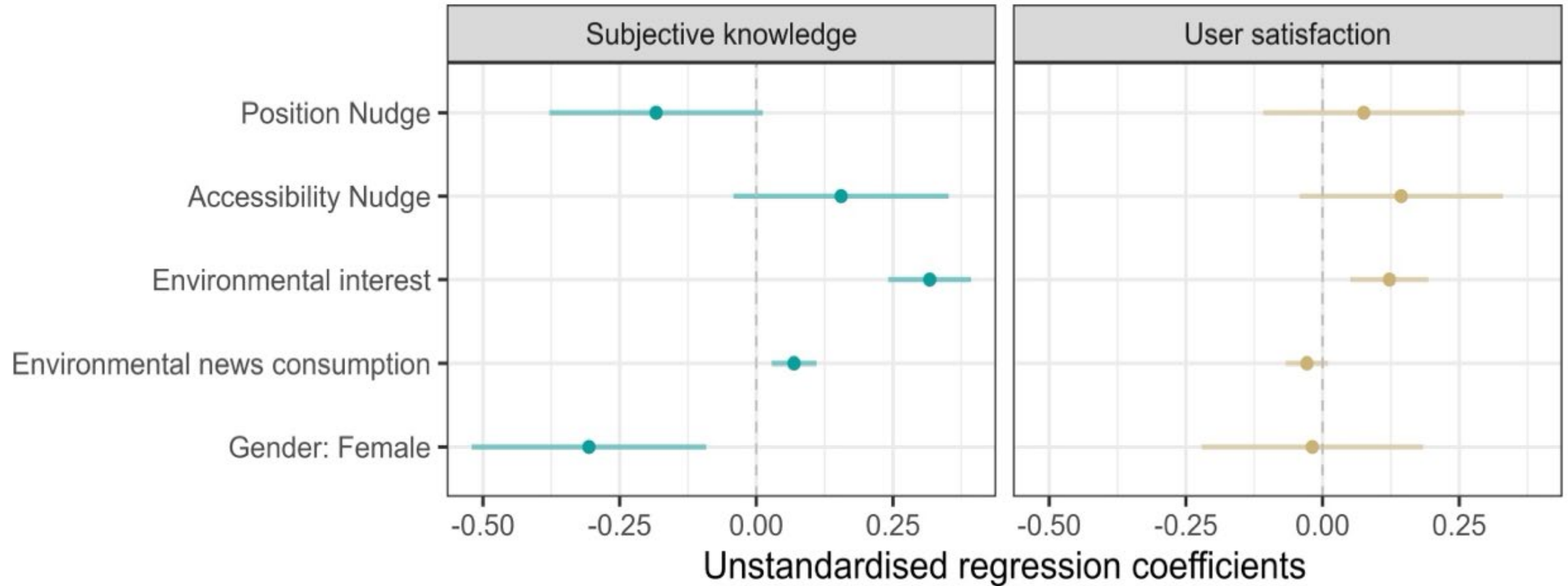
# Prominent positioning increases selection, engagement, and also recall



# Learning effects are driven by get-the gist questions



# Neither nudge made people mad



# Summary & outlook

- Content curation matters: Prominent article positioning increases news selection, engagement, and recall; lower text complexity does not.
- No negative effects on engagement or user satisfaction.
- Follow-up studies: We need more field experiments to look at different nudges and algorithms to gather empirical data.
- Looking for collaborators interested in using/hosting Informfully!

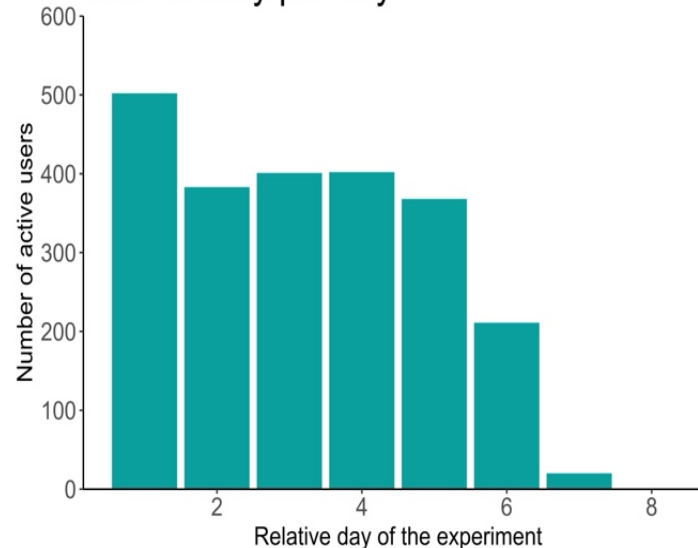
Questions? Reach out!

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# Experimental setup

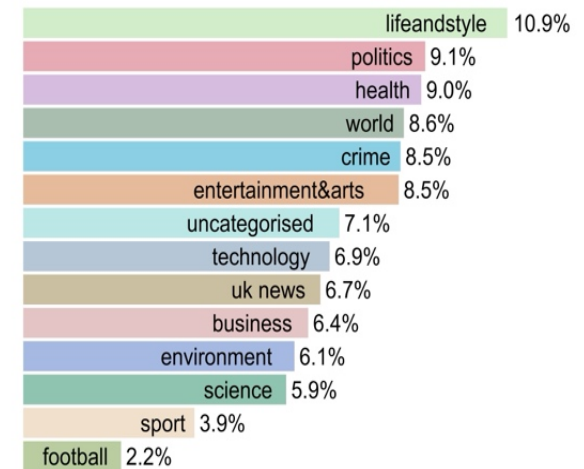
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- 2 x 2 experimental design
  - Position Nudge
  - Accessibility nudge

A User activity per day



B

News selections per topic



# References

- Helberger, N. (2021). On the democratic role of news recommenders. In *Algorithms, Automation, and News* (pp. 14-33). Routledge.
- Mattis, N., Groot Kormelink, T., Masur, P. K., Moeller, J., & van Atteveldt, W. (2024). Nudging News Readers: A Mixed-Methods Approach to Understanding When and How Interface Nudges Affect News Selection. *Digital Journalism*, 1-21.
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